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Strategies of status manipulation in the Wolof greeting

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Joking relationship (kall) and the joking greeting

Structurally the joking greeting contrasts with the normal greeting in the joking form's symmetry of speaking roles, a symmetry which reflects the overall effect of equality between the two speakers. Although the joking is usually initiated by A after both names have been exchanged, it does not really matter much which party initiates. B can sometimes initiate the joking instead of naming A:

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A. *Diop!* (B's name)

Diop! (B's name)

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B. *Sa sant Ndiaye neehul!*

Your surname Ndiaye is not pleasing!

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After the initiation of the joking greeting, there is no particular division of utterances into insults and responses: each speaker may insult the other without responding specifically to the other's insult of himself. It should also be noted that in the *kall* only stylized insults on conventional topics are permissible. Since the relationship depends on not being specific to individuals, personal insults or 'rudeness' of demeanor (to be described

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below) would change the interaction into something else that was no longer the *kall* or any other kind of greeting.

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The joking relationship provides, however, only a very limited opportunity to express equality. The *kall* involves only certain pairs of surnames, and any one person has only one or two surname groups in which to find joking partners. Some persons may find that their partner surnames are not even represented in the village. An effect of equality is more [183](#) frequently attained through mutual deference, whereby the normal greeting is recycled many times, the two speakers taking turns at the low-status role. Such an interchange - like the familiar 'after you, Alphonse' - may go on almost indefinitely.

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